

round — with the championship in his sights. This time, though, he faces a final sprint with both Lando Norris and Piastri alongside him — a showdown that wouldn't have existed had McLaren not let its advantage slip away.

The Vegas upheaval

At the Las Vegas Grand Prix — a star-studded spectacle that many drivers find too glamorous and bling-heavy for their liking — Norris arrived with the upper hand: a 24-point cushion over his teammate-rival, pole position on the street circuit, and a surge of confidence heading into the crucial triple-header.

Yet the threat of Verstappen starting from P2 was always potent. The Briton lost the lead on the opening lap and spent the rest of the race in pursuit. But Verstappen, who was 49 points behind, wasn't his 'closest' competitor, so a risky move was never considered.

He settled for second, with the comfort of knowing Piastri was not encroaching on his buffer. No one, however, expected a few sparks to ignite the wrong kind of fire. In the last few laps under the brightly lit Vegas strip, Norris' pace suddenly dropped. Excessive sparks had flickered from beneath his car, and he was asked to adjust his driving immediately. The Woking-based team seemed aware of the brewing problem, and that scrutineering would be unforgiving. After a long delay and detailed inspections, the FIA confirmed that both Norris and Piastri's MCL39s had exceeded the legal skid-wear limit — a crucial safety and performance measure preventing teams from running their cars too low.

Suddenly, McLaren had a Verstappen-sized problem at its garage door. The 28-year-old had clawed himself level with Piastri, and Norris now held only a 24-point advantage heading into the penultimate Qatar sprint and Grand Prix. Game on!



Close encounter: With Verstappen closing in, Norris still holds a marginal advantage as the three-way title battle enters its final chapter. REUTERS

Conundrum in Qatar

McLaren, the reigning constructors' champion, boasted the strongest car on the grid, brimming with performance and pace. Yet one area consistently eluded it: strategy — a weakness that proved costly in Qatar.

A reminder of Piastri's class arrived in the sprint, as he led from lights to flag at his most successful track. Norris finished third, Verstappen fourth, leaving the championship standings largely unchanged. Hours later, it was decided that the trio would line up first to third in the same order for Sunday's race.

A new rule was to complicate matters: Pirelli, concerned about tyre longevity, limited each compound to just 25 laps, requiring every car to pit twice over the 57-lap Doha circuit. Multiple strategies were possible if teams could react in time.

A Safety Car on lap seven, triggered by Nico Hulkenberg's crash, scrambled many plans. Almost all the drivers dived into the pits, with Verstappen leading the charge.

However, McLaren, caught off guard, missed the gamble entirely, unable to gain any edge from compound flexibility towards the closing stages.

Red Bull's pace and strategy proved flawless, right when it mattered most. Its lead driver crossed the line first, ahead of Piastri and Williams' Carlos Sainz. Norris had looked set for fifth but inherited fourth after Kimi Antonelli's last-lap error — crucial places saved but far from what was required.

For McLaren, it was a bitter blow. Piastri felt it most — once in command, now relegated to third due to a cruel mix of misfortune and missteps.

Norris still holds a marginal advantage as the three-way title battle enters its final chapter, but certainly with a dented spirit.

With countless permutations remaining, Norris holds the longer straw, and Yas Marina looms as the ultimate stage. The circuit that saw a dramatic, controversial finish in 2021 is now poised to deliver either a new champion or Verstappen his fifth title.